A 49-year-old former state electricity board employee. A retired government college English lecturer. A septuagenarian former high school Arabic teacher. A 36-year-old PhD in Islamic studies. A popular tailor. At first glance, these five individuals from disparate socioeconomic backgrounds have hardly anything in common. What does bind them together is that they were members of the Popular Front of India (PFI), an organisation the Union government declared "unlawful" through a notification on September 28, alleging their involvement in violent, extremist activities with scant regard for constitutional authority.

Hours after the announcement of a five-year ban on its activities, the front announced that it was disbanding itself. "As law-abiding citizens of our great country, the organisation accepts the decision of the ministry of home affairs.... All members of the PFI are requested to cease their activities," Kerala general secretary A. Abdul Sattar said in a statement.

The five individuals mentioned above and even Sattar, who was arrested sometime after he put out the statement, are among the 400-odd PFI activists arrested during a week-long joint operation by the National Investigation Agency (NIA), the Enforcement Directorate (ED) and state police forces across multiple states in India. The PFI professes that their organisation is a 'neo-social movement for the empowerment of marginalised sections in India', but the government agencies allege they are at the centre of a covert network that promotes Islamic terrorism funded by foreign forces, including Pakistan.

"Under the façade of social work, the PFI's many wings reached out to different sections of society such as the youth, students, women and working class," claims an NIA officer, "but the eventual goal was to indoctrinate and prime them for future terror acts. With the government going strong against external terror outfits, this was a conspiracy to strike India from within."

The central government notification says as much categorically. Exercising the powers conferred by sub-section (1) of Section 3 of the



WHY PFI HAS BEEN BANNED

In the notification declaring the PFI and its eight affiliated outfits unlawful, the Centre has brought the following charges against it

- It's pursuing a secret agenda to radicalise Muslims, undermine the concept of democracy and disrespect the Indian Constitution
- It supports militancy... has been indulging in unlawful and subversive activities, which are prejudicial to the integrity, sovereignty and security of the country, and to communal harmony
- Its founding members are linked to the banned SIMI; it has links with global terror groups such as the ISIS and Jamat-ul-Mujahideen Bangladesh
- It gets funds and ideological support from abroad; is involved in several criminal and terror cases, including attacks on activists of various social groups and political parties